



guards in the league, and wing defender Mikal Bridges, prised from the neighbouring Brooklyn Nets for a large trove of first-round picks. Rose also landed one of the league's most versatile defenders in OG Anunoby (**above**) from the Raptors, whose post-season play was among the key factors in the Knicks' triumph.

The Knicks had come close in previous seasons too, reaching the Eastern Conference Finals in 2025 — their first in a quarter-century — only to fall to the Indiana Pacers, two wins short of the Finals.

But under Tom Thibodeau they seemed to hit a ceiling: the veteran coach leaned on a tight rotation and heavy starter minutes, and the team grew predictable as it fell short each post-season. Brown, by contrast, trusted a far deeper bench across

both the regular season and playoffs, and managed his starters' minutes so they had something left when it mattered. The result was the title that had eluded the same core under Thibodeau.

The Spurs, meanwhile, had a fairytale run all season and into the playoffs. In just his third year, Wembanyama won the league's Defensive Player of the Year trophy unanimously.

He also significantly upped his offensive game and remained a cheat code for the Spurs, and was near-unsolvable for opponents until the NBA Finals.

He was helped by a young core that had quickly graduated into key rotation players. Sophomore guard Stephon Castle built on his Rookie of the Year performance from last year to become a solid two-way player.

Dylan Harper, the second pick of the 2025 NBA draft, was a revelation. His 'downhill' offensive game translated well from college to the pros as he eased his way to the rim and remained a key contributor deep into the post-season while also providing perimeter defence.

All-Star guard De'Aaron Fox fit well with the Spurs' unit, as his smooth point-guard play eased their offence throughout the regular season. Devin Vassell and Julian Champagnie played effective roles as wing players who spread the floor when needed. Veteran Spur Keldon Johnson won the Sixth Man of the Year award due to his strong play off the bench.

This three-guard core of Fox, Castle and Harper gave the Spurs the edge they needed to upend the Oklahoma City Thunder, a team they had tormented all year. San Antonio took the regular-season series 4-1 (including a win in the NBA Cup semifinals after snapping a franchise-record 16-game OKC winning streak).

By June, the defending champion finished just 4-8 against the Spurs while going 71-14 against everyone else. But it still took the Spurs seven games to oust the Thunder. San Antonio was banged up: Fox played through a high ankle sprain that limited him into the Finals, and Harper had an adductor issue that limited him in the Western Conference Finals (WCF).

But they also caught a break as the Thunder lost two key players — forward Jalen Williams to a hamstring strain and guard Ajay Mitchell to a calf injury — both sidelined for the decisive Game 7.

Very few teams have managed to become contenders in such a short period, and the Spurs will still be encouraged by their performance in 2025-26. Their core remains intact, and they will take the same lessons the Knicks learned — that a longer run in the post-season requires a deeper bench — and will rejig at their edges to provide more support to Wembanyama and the young core. NBA fans can hope that the Spurs-Thunder rivalry continues for